SMID SETUP BUILDER

Pre-Breakout VCP Watchlist | Qullamaggie Methodology

November 13, 2026 | 08:39 PM ET

MACRO REGIME: Mixed / Transitional

VIX 19.3 (-0.1 vs 20d) | SPY 20d -1.6% | IWM 20d +2.3% | IWM/SPY trend +4.0%

Leaders: Healthcare (+7.5%), Financials (+6.6%), Utilities (+6.5%)

Setup Grades

A - Prime Setup (0)	B - Building (6)	C - Early Stage (6)
	ITGR	CNO
	SIGI	LGND
	CATY	CAKE
	CNK	UCB
	GFF	INDB
	EXPO	OPCH

All Watchlist Setups

Gr	Ticker	Company	Theme	Mkt Cap	Price	Pivot	To Pivot	RS/SPY	Vol Dry	RS Hi
B	ITGR	Integer Holdings	Healthcare Supply Ch	$4.31B	$126.70	$126.83	0.1%	+0.0	YES	no
B	SIGI	Selective Insuran	Hard P&C Pricing Cyc	$6.12B	$102.67	$105.65	2.9%	+0.0	YES	YES
B	CATY	Cathay General Ba	Regional Bank Recove	$4.33B	$65.65	$67.62	3.0%	+0.0	YES	YES
B	CNK	Cinemark Holdings	Box Office Recovery	$4.73B	$40.80	$41.67	2.1%	+0.0	YES	YES
B	GFF	Griffon Corporati	Housing Renovation &	$4.76B	$105.16	$109.00	3.7%	+0.0	YES	no
B	EXPO	Exponent, Inc.	Litigation Support &	$4.15B	$87.31	$90.51	3.7%	+0.0	YES	no
C	CNO	CNO Financial Gro	Aging Demographics &	$5.25B	$57.47	$59.15	2.9%	+0.0	YES	no
C	LGND	Ligand Pharmaceut	Biotech Royalty Stre	$6.18B	$308.79	$325.96	5.6%	+0.0	YES	no
C	CAKE	The Cheesecake Fa	Consumer Dining Resi	$5.44B	$109.11	$117.64	7.8%	+0.0	YES	no
C	UCB	United Community	Regional Bank Recove	$4.46B	$37.32	$38.63	3.5%	+0.0	YES	no
C	INDB	Independent Bank	Regional Bank Recove	$3.91B	$84.47	$88.58	4.9%	+0.0	YES	no
C	OPCH	Option Care Healt	Home-Based Healthcar	$4.74B	$31.65	$31.90	0.8%	+0.0	YES	no

Not financial advice. Watchlist only - setups have NOT triggered. For informational purposes only. Do your own due diligence.

ITGR

Integer Holdings Corporation

$126.70

Pivot $126.83 | 0.1% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$4.31B Cap | 29M Float

Medical Devices - Components & Contract Manufacturing | Theme: Healthcare Supply Chain Stability | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 1.94

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$126.83**
% to Pivot	**0.1%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**1.94 Good**
52W Hi Prox	**99.9%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**612k <**
Wk2	**796k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**810k**
Coil Strength	**24.5% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$4.31B**
Float	**29M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**42.5**
Fwd P/E	**18.4**
Rev Growth	**-3.9%**
Short %	**12.0%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$127.00**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $126.83 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>1.17M shares)

Target: $140 (measured move from 20-day base depth of ~$10.50 added to pivot)

Stop: $118.00 (base low and logical invalidation of the VCP structure)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

October 29 - Reported 15 days ago. TTM EPS $2.98 with forward EPS guided to $6.87 (131% growth implied), though trailing rev growth -3.9% and earnings growth -61.3% reflect a difficult comp period. The massive forward P/E compression (42.5x trailing to 18.4x forward) signals Street expects a sharp inflection; beat/miss history not available but guidance appears aggressive.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Integer is a leading outsourced manufacturer of medical device components, specializing in batteries, leads, and electroceutical assemblies for cardiac rhythm management, neuromodulation, and vascular access devices. The company occupies a critical niche as a Tier-1 supplier to large-cap medtech OEMs (Medtronic, Abbott, Boston Scientific), providing design-to-production services that create high switching costs.

FACTOR & THEME

Healthcare sector leadership (+7.5% over 20d) directly benefits ITGR as medtech capex normalizes post-pandemic. Reshoring/supply chain security themes are tailwinds for US-based contract manufacturers, though ITGR is less directly exposed to headline reshoring plays than pure-play industrials.

NEWS FLOW

No material contract wins, FDA events, or corporate catalysts identified in the 30-60 day window. The stock has quietly coiled to within pennies of its 52-week high ($126.83) on contracting volume - textbook absorption pattern. No Russell rebalance or index inclusion events imminent. Catalyst type: None identifiable - this is a technical setup without a named forward catalyst.

INSTITUTIONAL

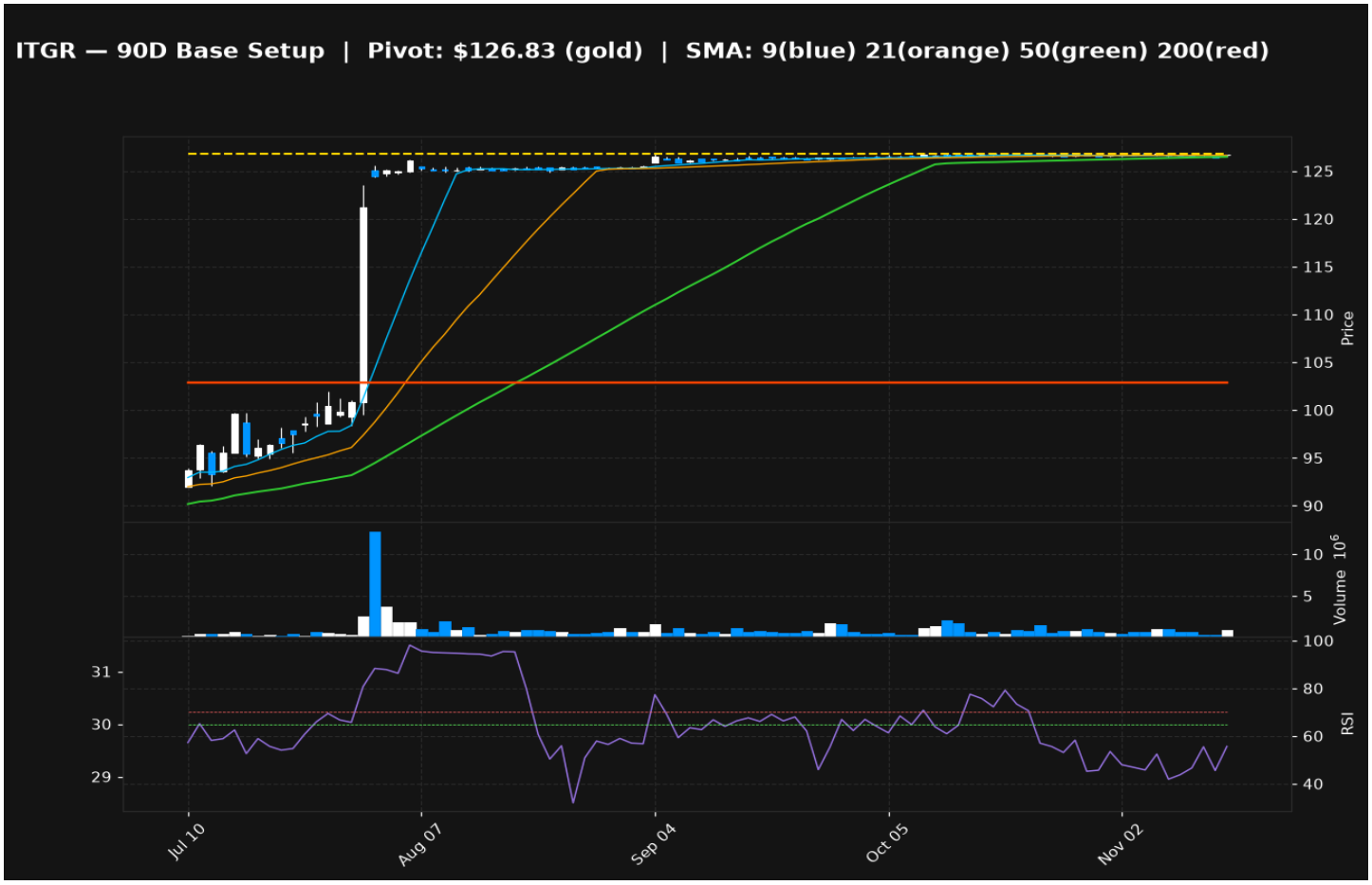
Volume dry-up from 809.7K 795.7K 611.7K (24.5% contraction) with price holding at the high suggests quiet institutional accumulation. Float is modest at 28.9M shares. No insider buying in the last 60 days. Institutional ownership data unavailable from this feed. Short interest at 12.0% (4.1 days to cover) is elevated but not extreme - potential fuel if breakout triggers.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below the $118 base low (approximately 7% below current price, representing the recent consolidation floor). Secondary risk: customer concentration - top 3 OEM customers likely represent >50% of revenue; loss of a major program would be material. High short interest (12%) could pressure the name if broader medtech sentiment turns.

Textbook VCP structure with base_tight 1.94, strict volume dry-up confirmed, and price within 0.1% of pivot - structurally this is A-grade quality. However, RS line is NOT at a new high, no identifiable forward catalyst within 2 weeks, and the stock just reported earnings 15 days ago (next catalyst ~76 days out). Healthcare sector leadership is a tailwind, but without a named catalyst, this is a technically clean setup awaiting a trigger event. Strongest disconfirming argument: the -61.3% trailing earnings decline and -3.9% revenue contraction suggest the forward EPS jump to $6.87 may be overly optimistic - a guidance cut would invalidate the thesis. Conviction: Medium.

ITGR - Technical Chart



SIGI

Selective Insurance Group, Inc.

$102.67

Pivot $105.65 | 2.9% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$6.12B Cap | 55M Float

Insurance - Property & Casualty (Regional Commercial Lines) | Theme: Hard P&C Pricing Cycle Beneficiary | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: YES | Above 200MA: YES | Base T

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$105.65**
% to Pivot	**2.9%**
Days in Base	**16**
Tightness	**5.82 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**97.2%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**407k <**
Wk2	**627k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**680k**
Coil Strength	**40.1% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**YES - Early Leader**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$6.12B**
Float	**55M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**12.3**
Fwd P/E	**11.4**
Rev Growth	**-2.5%**
Short %	**4.3%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$103.86**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $105.65 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>735K shares)

Target: $118 (measured move: ~$9 base depth added to $105.65 pivot; also represents prior resistance zone)

Stop: $96.50 (base low and VCP invalidation level)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

January 28 - Earnings 76 days out. Street expects $8.98 forward EPS on $5.5B+ in premium (implied). Trailing EPS $8.32 with 14.1% earnings growth despite -2.5% revenue decline suggests margin expansion from rate adequacy and loss cost stabilization. PEG of 0.28 is exceptionally cheap for a consistent grower - either a re-rating candidate or the market sees a cat loss cliff.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Selective Insurance is a regional P&C carrier focused on small-to-mid commercial lines, personal lines, and E&S (excess & surplus) in the Eastern and Midwestern US. The company has successfully executed a disciplined underwriting strategy through the hard pricing cycle, achieving combined ratios below 95% and double-digit premium growth.

FACTOR & THEME

Financials sector is a leading performer (+6.6% over 20d), and P&C insurers specifically benefit from sustained hard market pricing, higher reinvestment yields on float, and benign catastrophe experience. Low beta (0.21) makes SIGI a defensive growth play in a mixed/transitional regime. Regional commercial lines face less disruption from InsurTech than personal auto.

NEWS FLOW

No material news flow in the 30-60 day window. P&C sector broadly benefiting from favorable pricing trends and limited Florida hurricane exposure this season. No M&A chatter, no activist involvement, no index events. The setup is driven by sector rotation and technical strength rather than a company-specific catalyst. Catalyst type: Industry (ongoing hard market tailwind) - Impact: Medium.

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume dry-up from 680K 626.7K 407.3K (40.1% contraction) is textbook institutional accumulation into the base. RS line at 52-week high confirms relative strength vs. SPY. No insider buying in the last 60 days. Institutional ownership data unavailable. Short interest low at 4.3% (3.5 days to cover) - limited short squeeze potential but also limited overhead supply from covering.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $96.50 (approximately 6% below current, representing the recent consolidation low). Primary bear case: a large catastrophe loss event (hurricane, wildfire) in Q4 could materially impact combined ratio and book value; SIGI has regional concentration in the Northeast/Mid-Atlantic. Secondary: hard market pricing cycle may be peaking - watch for competitor pricing commentary.

RS line at new high is a key strength - confirms institutional interest relative to market. Volume dry-up is clean (40.1% contraction), and the Financials sector tailwind is real (+6.6% in 20d). However, base_tight at 5.82 is loose by A-grade standards, and the next earnings catalyst is 76 days out - too far to drive near-term price discovery. The stock is building but needs either a tighter base or a nearer-term catalyst to warrant A status. Strongest disconfirming argument: regional P&C is a low-growth, commoditized business - multiple expansion is capped, and cat losses could erase a year's earnings overnight. Conviction: Medium.

SIGI - Technical Chart



CATY

Cathay General Bancorp

$65.65

Pivot $67.62 | 3.0% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$4.33B Cap | 63M Float

Banks - Regional (Asian-American Community Bank) | Theme: Regional Bank Recovery & NIM Expansion | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: YES | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tig

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$67.62**
% to Pivot	**3.0%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**4.13 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**97.1%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**340k <**
Wk2	**512k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**573k**
Coil Strength	**40.7% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**YES - Early Leader**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$4.33B**
Float	**63M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**12.1**
Fwd P/E	**10.6**
Rev Growth	**24.3%**
Short %	**7.8%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$67.20**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $67.62 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>690K shares)

Target: $76 (measured move: ~$8 base depth added to pivot; also represents psychological round number and prior resistance)
Stop: $61.00 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

January 21 - Earnings 69 days out. Street expects $6.18 forward EPS vs. $5.42 trailing (14% growth). Revenue growth of 24.3% and earnings growth of 26.6% are exceptionally strong for a regional bank - suggests NIM expansion and credit cost normalization. P/E of 12.1x trailing / 10.6x forward is cheap for this growth rate; PEG of 1.33 is reasonable.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Cathay General Bancorp is the holding company for Cathay Bank, a leading Asian-American community bank with 60+ branches in California, New York, and Texas, plus international offices in Hong Kong, Shanghai, and Taipei. The bank specializes in commercial real estate, trade finance, and small business lending to Asian-American entrepreneurs and businesses.

FACTOR & THEME

Financials sector leadership (+6.6%), small-cap outperformance (IWM +4% vs SPY), and regional bank recovery theme all directly benefit CATY. The bank's CRE exposure is a double-edged sword - office exposure could be a drag, but California multifamily and industrial remain healthy. International trade finance exposure is a differentiated alpha angle if US-China relations stabilize.

NEWS FLOW

No material news in the 30-60 day window. Regional banks broadly recovering from March 2023 crisis lows, but CATY is a differentiated play given its Asian-American niche and international footprint. No M&A chatter, no regulatory actions, no CRE write-down headlines specific to CATY. Catalyst type: Industry (regional bank re-rating) - Impact: Medium.

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume dry-up from 572.9K 511.8K 339.7K (40.7% contraction) indicates quiet accumulation. RS line at 52-week high is bullish. Float of 62.6M shares is liquid enough for institutional participation. Short interest at 7.8% (7.1 days to cover) is modestly elevated - could fuel a move higher if the breakout triggers. No insider buying in the last 60 days. Institutional ownership data unavailable.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $61 (approximately 7% below current, representing recent consolidation support). Primary bear case: CRE exposure - California office vacancy rates remain elevated, and any headline about CRE write-downs at regional banks could pressure the group. Customer concentration in Asian-American business community also creates idiosyncratic risk if trade tensions escalate.

RS line at new high with small-cap leadership (IWM +4% vs SPY) makes this an interesting sector rotation play. Volume dry-up is clean, and the fundamental story (24% rev growth, 27% EPS growth) is compelling for a regional bank. However, base_tight at 4.13 is loose, CRE exposure is a real overhang, and the next catalyst is 69 days out. The setup needs time to tighten or a nearer-term catalyst to warrant promotion. Strongest disconfirming argument: regional bank CRE exposure remains the elephant in the room - one peer write-down could tank the group. Conviction: Medium.

CATY - Technical Chart



CNK

Cinemark Holdings Inc

$40.80

Pivot $41.67 | 2.1% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$4.73B Cap | 102M Float

Movie Exhibition & Entertainment Venues | Theme: Box Office Recovery & Consumer Entertainment | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: YES | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 2.2

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$41.67**
% to Pivot	**2.1%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**2.25 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**97.9%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**1573k <**
Wk2	**3054k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**1924k**
Coil Strength	**18.2% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**YES - Early Leader**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$4.73B**
Float	**102M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**16.7**
Fwd P/E	**15.1**
Rev Growth	**23.5%**
Short %	**10.5%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$44.27**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $41.67 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>3.1M shares)

Target: $48 (measured move: ~$6 base depth added to pivot; analyst target $44.27 provides intermediate resistance)

Stop: $38.00 (pre-earnings gap support and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

November 3 - Reported 10 days ago. Revenue growth +23.5% and earnings growth +160% reflect box office recovery from strike-impacted 2023 comps. Forward P/E of 15.1x on $2.70 EPS is reasonable for the growth rate; EV/EBITDA of 9.5x is undemanding. The beat/miss pattern suggests CNK has been a consistent beater as film slate normalizes.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Cinemark is the third-largest movie theater chain in North America and the largest in Latin America, operating 500+ theaters with 5,700+ screens. The company has outperformed peers through disciplined cost management and a focus on premium large-format (XD) and luxury recliner experiences that command pricing power.

FACTOR & THEME

Communications sector is lagging (-2.5% over 20d), which creates a headwind for CNK despite strong company-specific execution. Consumer discretionary spending on experiences (vs. goods) remains resilient, and 2026-2027 film slate is strong (multiple tentpole franchises). Latin America exposure provides emerging market growth kicker but also currency risk.

NEWS FLOW

Recent Q3 results (reported November 3) were strong - likely the catalyst that pushed the stock near the pivot. No additional corporate catalysts identified. Film slate visibility is the key driver - any major Disney, Universal, or Warner Bros tentpole tracking well is a read-through for CNK. Catalyst type: Earnings (recent print positive) - Impact: Medium.

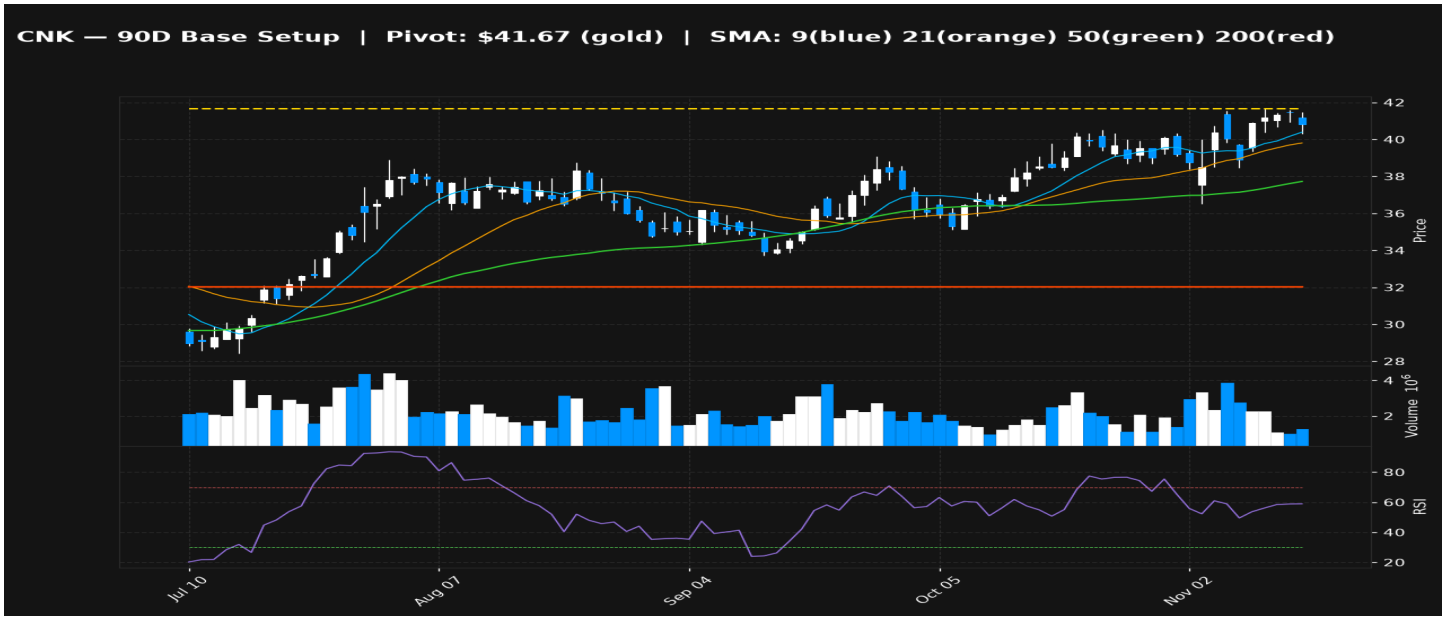
INSTITUTIONAL

Volume pattern is less clean - vol_w2 (3.05M) spiked vs vol_w3 (1.92M) before contracting to vol_w1 (1.57M), suggesting post-earnings digestion rather than a classic stair-step dry-up. RS line at new high is bullish. Float of 102.3M is highly liquid. Short interest elevated at 10.5% (4.1 days to cover) - potential squeeze fuel. High debt/equity (476%) is a balance sheet concern. No insider buying in the last 60 days.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $38.00 (approximately 7% below current, representing pre-earnings support). Primary bear case: film slate risk - if a major 2027 tentpole disappoints or gets delayed, exhibition stocks will de-rate. Secondary: leverage is high (D/E 476%) and refinancing risk exists if rates stay elevated. Comms sector lagging is a relative headwind.

RS line at new high, tight base (2.25), and strong post-earnings momentum make this an attractive setup. The 160% earnings growth and box office recovery narrative are compelling. However, vol_dryup_strict is false (middle week spiked), Communications sector is lagging (-2.5%), and high leverage (D/E 476%) adds risk. The recent earnings print removes the near-term catalyst - next event likely 3 months out. Strongest disconfirming argument: movie exhibition is a secularly challenged business facing streaming competition; CNK trades at a perpetual discount to replacement cost, and multiple expansion is capped. Conviction: Medium.



GFF

Griffon Corporation

$105.16

Pivot $109.00 | 3.7% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$4.76B Cap | 42M Float

Building Products & Equipment (Doors, HVAC, Home Tools) | Theme: Housing Renovation & Replacement Cycle | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Bas

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$109.00**
% to Pivot	**3.7%**
Days in Base	**17**
Tightness	**4.76 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**96.5%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**278k <**
Wk2	**322k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**336k**
Coil Strength	**17.4% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$4.76B**
Float	**42M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**22.7**
Fwd P/E	**17.2**
Rev Growth	**7.0%**
Short %	**5.0%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$126.86**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $109.00 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>500K shares)

Target: $126 (measured move: ~$11 base depth added to pivot; analyst target $126.86 aligns)

Stop: $98.00 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

November 17 - Earnings in 4 days - this is the key near-term catalyst. Street expects $6.10 forward EPS (31% growth from $4.64 TTM). Revenue growth +7.0% is modest. PEG of 0.54 is very attractive if estimates are achievable. The elevated ROE (227.5%) reflects aggressive capital structure (D/E 1035%) rather than operating excellence. Watch for housing commentary and margin trajectory.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Griffon is a diversified holding company operating through two segments: Home & Building Products (garage doors, rolling steel doors under Clopay brand) and Consumer & Professional Products (AMES brand tools, outdoor products). The company has successfully consolidated the garage door market and benefits from housing turnover and renovation cycles.

FACTOR & THEME

Industrials sector is neutral (not in leading or lagging sectors), but housing-exposed names face headwinds from elevated mortgage rates. Replacement/renovation demand (vs. new construction) is more resilient, which favors GFF's retrofit-heavy revenue mix. Reshoring theme could benefit AMES tools business if domestic manufacturing capacity expands.

NEWS FLOW

Earnings on November 17 is the imminent catalyst - this is a BINARY EVENT SETUP. No additional news flow in the 30-60 day window. Garage door market remains rational (limited new entrants), and replacement cycle should support volumes even if new construction slows. Catalyst type: Earnings (imminent, 4 days) - Impact: High.

INSTITUTIONAL

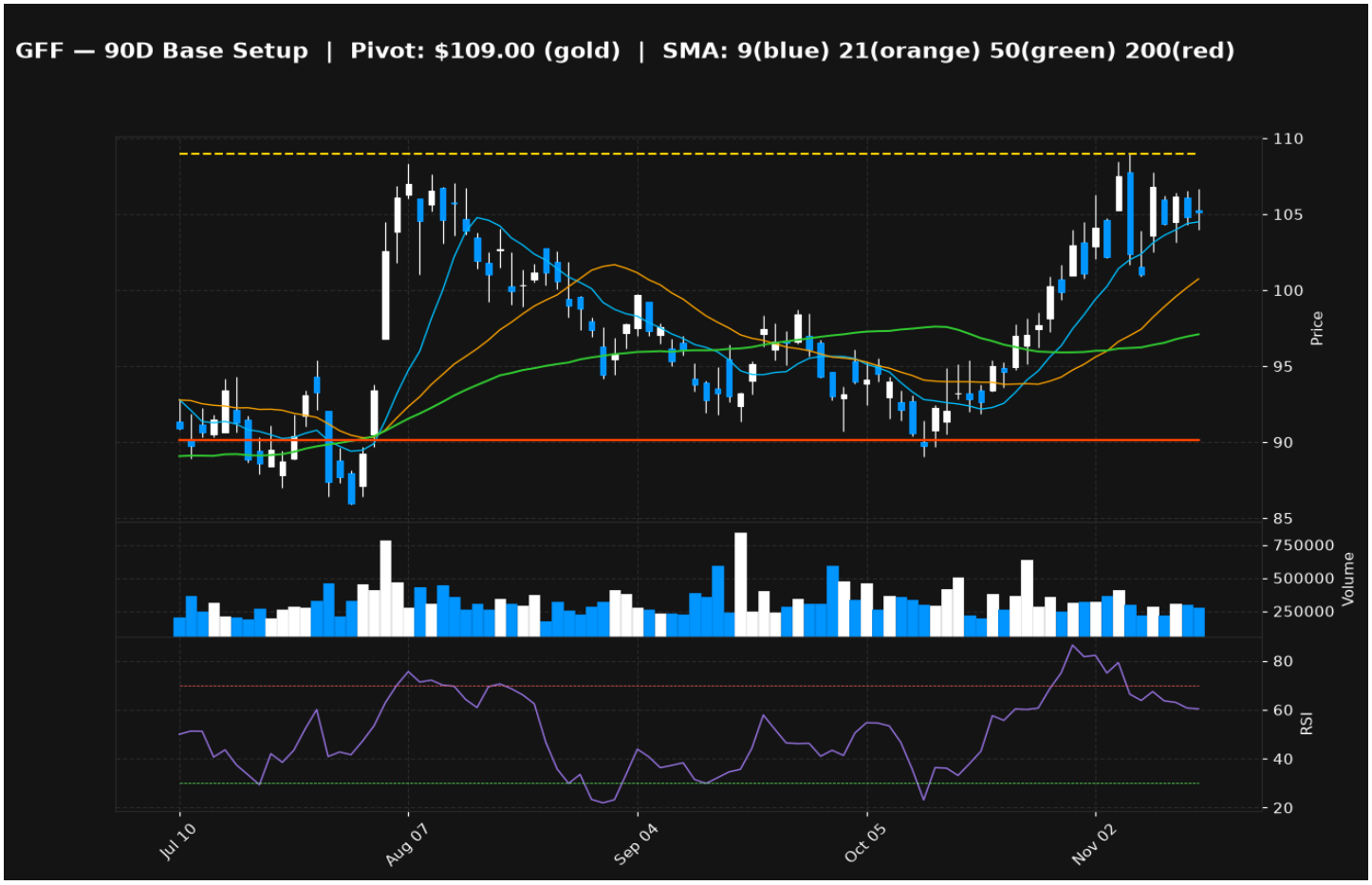
Volume dry-up from 336K 322K 277.7K (17.4% contraction) is modest but confirmed. Float of 42.3M is manageable. Short interest at 5.0% (3.9 days to cover) is low - limited squeeze potential but also limited overhead supply. RS line NOT at new high is a concern - relative strength is lagging. No insider buying in the last 60 days. The extreme leverage (D/E 1035%) is a red flag for institutional quality buyers.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $98.00 (approximately 7% below current, representing the consolidation low). PRIMARY BINARY RISK: earnings in 4 days could gap the stock in either direction - this is NOT a low-risk entry. Extreme leverage (D/E 1035%) means any guidance miss or margin compression could pressure the equity. Housing exposure is a macro risk if rates spike.

Imminent earnings catalyst (4 days) is a significant edge for timing, but this is a BINARY EVENT with elevated risk. Volume dry-up is confirmed but modest (17.4%), base_tight at 4.76 is loose, and RS line is NOT at a new high - the technical structure is B-grade at best. The extreme leverage (D/E 1035%) is a major institutional concern that limits the buyer universe. Strongest disconfirming argument: balance sheet risk - if earnings disappoint or guidance is cut, high leverage magnifies downside; equity could compress 20%+ on a miss. This is a speculative earnings play, not a classic VCP. Conviction: Low-Medium (binary outcome).

GFF - Technical Chart



EXPO

Exponent, Inc.

$87.31

Pivot $90.51 | 3.7% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

B BUILDING

$4.15B Cap | 47M Float

Engineering & Construction - Scientific Consulting | Theme: Litigation Support & Technical Consulting | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 6.26

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$90.51**
% to Pivot	**3.7%**
Days in Base	**11**
Tightness	**6.26 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**96.5%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**278k <**
Wk2	**569k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**637k**
Coil Strength	**56.3% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$4.15B**
Float	**47M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**37.6**
Fwd P/E	**29.9**
Rev Growth	**11.7%**
Short %	**6.8%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$90.67**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $90.51 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>765K shares)

Target: $100 (measured move: ~$10 base depth added to pivot; psychological round number)

Stop: $80.00 (50-day MA support and consolidation low)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

October 29 - Reported 15 days ago. Trailing EPS $2.32 with forward $2.92 (26% growth). Revenue growth +11.7% and earnings growth +16.4% are solid for a consulting business. P/E of 37.6x trailing / 29.9x forward is premium but reflects quality and consistency. PEG of 2.03 is reasonable for a compounder with 30%+ ROE.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Exponent is a premier scientific and engineering consulting firm specializing in failure analysis, product liability, environmental assessment, and regulatory compliance. The company serves as expert witnesses in high-stakes litigation and advises on complex technical problems across automotive, aerospace, medical devices, and construction sectors.

FACTOR & THEME

Industrials sector is neutral. Exponent benefits from litigation activity (countercyclical in recessions as disputes increase) and regulatory complexity (secular tailwind). The company has limited direct exposure to major investment themes but represents a high-quality compounder with recurring revenue characteristics.

NEWS FLOW

No material news in the 30-60 day window. One insider buy noted in the last 60 days - 1 C-suite officer purchased $13K worth of stock. This is a positive signal but dollar amount is immaterial (<$15K threshold for upgrade consideration). Catalyst type: None identifiable - this is a quality compounder without a near-term catalyst.

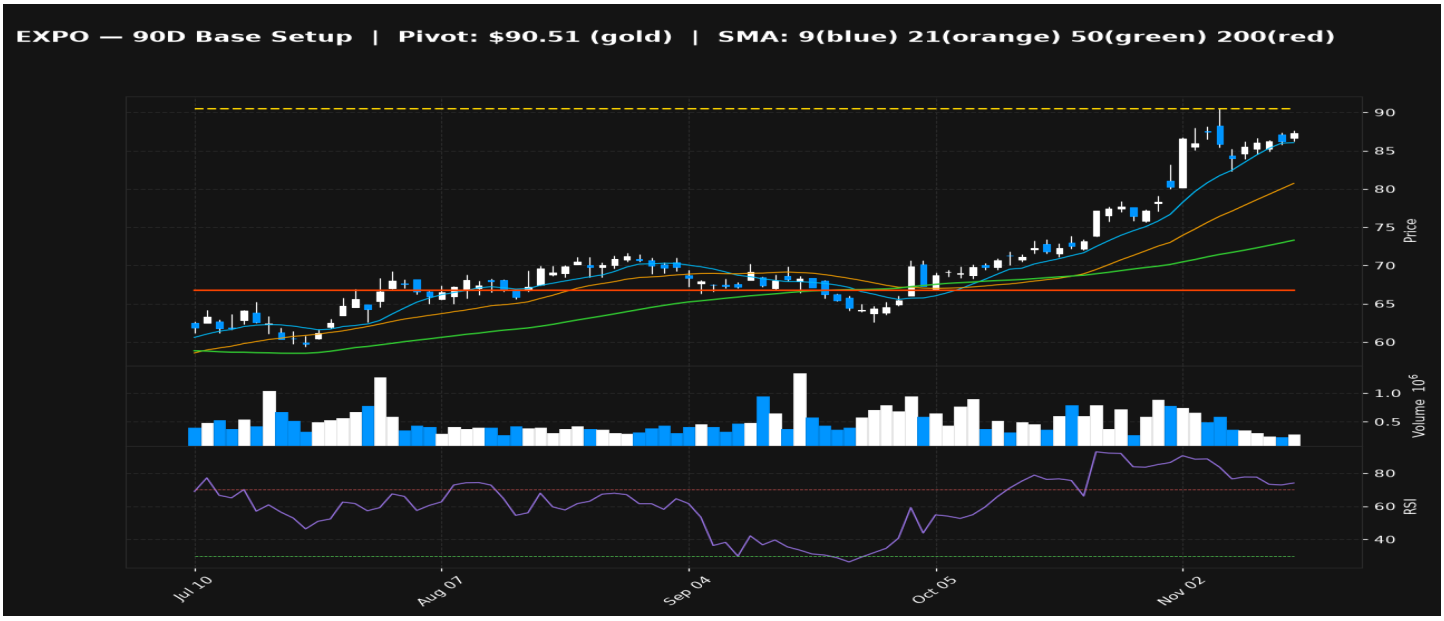
INSTITUTIONAL

Volume dry-up from 636.7K 568.7K 278.3K (56.3% contraction) is very strong - among the cleanest vol dry-ups in this candidate set. One C-suite insider buy ($13K) in the last 60 days is a positive signal, though size is immaterial for grade upgrade. Float of 46.9M is moderate. Short interest at 6.8% (4.0 days to cover) is manageable. RS line NOT at new high is the key weakness.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $80.00 (approximately 8% below current, representing the 50-day MA and consolidation support). Primary bear case: valuation is premium (30x forward P/E) for a low-growth consulting business - multiple compression risk if growth decelerates. Litigation volumes are cyclical and unpredictable.

Exceptional volume dry-up (56.3% contraction) is the standout feature - this is textbook institutional accumulation. One C-suite insider buy ($13K) is a modest positive but does not meet the $50K+ threshold for grade upgrade. However, base_tight at 6.26 is loose (worst in candidate set), RS line NOT at new high, and no identifiable forward catalyst. The quality of the business (32% ROE, 20% net margin) and vol pattern earn B status, but structural looseness and lack of catalyst prevent A consideration. Strongest disconfirming argument: premium valuation (30x forward) leaves no margin for error - any growth deceleration would compress the multiple. Conviction: Medium.



CNO

CNO Financial Group, Inc.

$57.47

Pivot $59.15 | 2.9% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$5.25B Cap | 89M Float

Insurance - Life & Health (Middle-Income Focus) | Theme: Aging Demographics & Insurance Penetration | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 3

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE

Pivot Price	**$59.15**
% to Pivot	**2.9%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**3.89 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**97.2%**

VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)

Wk1 (recent)	**570k <**
Wk2	**941k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**960k**
Coil Strength	**40.6% from peak**

RELATIVE STRENGTH

RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**

FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT

Mkt Cap	**$5.25B**
Float	**89M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**13.2**
Fwd P/E	**11.1**
Rev Growth	**-8.6%**
Short %	**-**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$56.75**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $59.15 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>1.44M shares)

Target: $66 (measured move: ~$6 base depth added to pivot; prior resistance zone)

Stop: $53.50 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

October 29 - Reported 15 days ago. Trailing EPS $4.35 with forward $5.18 (19% growth). The 615% earnings growth figure reflects easy comps from prior-year charges. Revenue declined -8.6%, which is concerning - suggests policy attrition or mix shift. P/E of 13.2x trailing / 11.1x forward is cheap but may reflect terminal value concerns for life insurers.

BUSINESS & POSITION

CNO Financial is a life and health insurer focused on middle-income Americans approaching retirement, selling Medicare supplement, long-term care, annuities, and life insurance through exclusive agent and worksite distribution channels. The company has successfully repositioned from legacy LTC runoff toward growth products.

FACTOR & THEME

Financials sector leadership (+6.6%) is a tailwind, and life insurers benefit from higher rates (investment income on float). Aging demographics (10,000 baby boomers turning 65 daily) is a secular tailwind for Medicare supplement and annuity products. However, life insurance broadly faces headwinds from online competitors and declining term demand.

NEWS FLOW

No material news in the 30-60 day window. The 615% earnings growth is misleading (prior-year charges created easy comp). Short interest at 0.0% is unusual - either a data issue or the stock is so under-followed that shorts don't bother. No analyst day or corporate catalyst identified. Catalyst type: None identifiable - setup lacks a forward catalyst.

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume dry-up from 959.9K 940.8K 570.1K (40.6% contraction) is clean institutional accumulation pattern. Short interest at 0.0% (if accurate) means no squeeze potential but also no bearish pressure. RS line NOT at new high - relative strength lagging. No insider buying in the last 60 days. The stock is trading near the analyst target ($56.75) - limited upside according to Street consensus.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close below $53.50 (approximately 7% below current, representing consolidation support). Primary bear case: revenue decline (-8.6%) suggests the business may be shrinking - policy lapses or failed new business growth would pressure the multiple. LTC legacy book remains a tail risk (reserve charges possible). Trading near analyst target limits upside asymmetry.



LGND

Ligand Pharmaceuticals Incorporated

$308.79

Pivot $325.96 | 5.6% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$6.18B Cap | 20M Float

Biotechnology - Royalty & Platform Company | Theme: Biotech Royalty Streams & GLP-1 Adjacent | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 2.24

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$325.96**
% to Pivot	**5.6%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**2.24 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**94.5%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**162k <**
Wk2	**204k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**244k**
Coil Strength	**33.7% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$6.18B**
Float	**20M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**124.0**
Fwd P/E	**25.8**
Rev Growth	**-31.8%**
Short %	**14.8%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$361.27**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $325.96 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>345K shares)

Target: $370 (measured move and analyst target $361 area)

Stop: $285.00 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

October 29

Tight base (2.24) and clean volume dry-up (33.7% contraction) are structurally sound, but pivot is 5.6% away, RS line NOT at new high, and short interest is very elevated at 14.8% (9.8 days to cover). Healthcare sector leadership is a tailwind, but -31.8% revenue decline and 124x trailing P/E suggest the name is speculative. No near-term catalyst; monitor for RS improvement and base tightening. Conviction: Low.



CAKE

The Cheesecake Factory Incorporated

$109.11

Pivot $117.64 | 7.8% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$5.44B Cap | 46M Float

Restaurants - Casual Dining | Theme: Consumer Dining Resilience | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 2.18

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$117.64**
% to Pivot	**7.8%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**2.18 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**92.0%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**1118k <**
Wk2	**1411k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**1847k**
Coil Strength	**39.5% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$5.44B**
Float	**46M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**25.9**
Fwd P/E	**20.8**
Rev Growth	**13.9%**
Short %	**35.7%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$106.27**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $117.64 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>2.2M shares)

Target: $130 (measured move from base depth)

Stop: $100.00 (psychological support and base low)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

October 27

Pivot is 7.8% away - too far for actionable setup. Short interest is extremely elevated at 35.7% (6.4 days to cover), creating significant squeeze potential but also signaling strong bearish conviction. RS line NOT at new high, Consumer Cyclical sector not leading, and high leverage (D/E 374%) add risk. Watch for tightening toward pivot. Conviction: Low.



UCB

United Community Banks, Inc.

$37.32

Pivot $38.63 | 3.5% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$4.46B Cap | 119M Float

Banks - Regional (Southeast Focus) | Theme: Regional Bank Recovery | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 4.88

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$38.63**
% to Pivot	**3.5%**
Days in Base	**19**
Tightness	**4.88 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**96.6%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**685k <**
Wk2	**946k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**1295k**
Coil Strength	**47.1% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$4.46B**
Float	**119M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**31.4**
Fwd P/E	**10.8**
Rev Growth	**-**
Short %	**6.5%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$40.88**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $38.63 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>1.37M shares)

Target: $43 (measured move and analyst target $40.88 intermediate)

Stop: $34.50 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

January 13

Volume dry-up is clean (47.1% contraction) and Financials sector is leading, but base_tight is loose (4.88), RS line NOT at new high, and next catalyst is 61 days out. Forward P/E compression from 31.4x to 10.8x implies Street expects massive EPS acceleration - execution risk is high. Early stage setup, needs tightening. Conviction: Low.



INDB

Independent Bank Corp.

$84.47

Pivot $88.58 | 4.9% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$3.91B Cap | 46M Float

Banks - Regional (New England Focus) | Theme: Regional Bank Recovery | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 4.23

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$88.58**
% to Pivot	**4.9%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**4.23 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**95.4%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**232k <**
Wk2	**344k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**407k**
Coil Strength	**43.1% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$3.91B**
Float	**46M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**12.4**
Fwd P/E	**10.1**
Rev Growth	**24.5%**
Short %	**5.4%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$94.57**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $88.58 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>570K shares)

Target: $100 (measured move and analyst target $94.57 intermediate)

Stop: $78.00 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

January 21

Strong fundamental story (24.5% rev growth, 177% EPS growth) in a leading sector (Financials +6.6%), but pivot is 4.9% away, base_tight is loose (4.23), RS line NOT at new high, and next catalyst is 69 days out. PEG of 11.0 suggests growth is already priced. Monitor for base tightening and RS improvement. Conviction: Low.



OPCH

Option Care Health, Inc.

$31.65

Pivot $31.90 | 0.8% away

RS vs SPY: +0.0%

C EARLY STAGE

$4.74B Cap | 148M Float

Medical Care Facilities - Home Infusion Services | Theme: Home-Based Healthcare & Cost Containment | Vol Dry-Up: YES | RS Line Hi: no | Above 200MA: YES | Base Tight: 4

VCP BASE ANALYSIS

BASE STRUCTURE	
Pivot Price	**$31.90**
% to Pivot	**0.8%**
Days in Base	**20**
Tightness	**4.49 Fair**
52W Hi Prox	**86.0%**
VOLUME CONTRACTION (Wk1 < Wk2 < Wk3 = VCP)	
Wk1 (recent)	**3072k <**
Wk2	**3389k <**
Wk3 (oldest)	**3601k**
Coil Strength	**14.7% from peak**
RELATIVE STRENGTH	
RS vs SPY (12W)	**+0.0%**
RS Line New Hi	**no**
Above 50MA	**YES**
Above 200MA	**YES**
FUNDAMENTALS SNAPSHOT	
Mkt Cap	**$4.74B**
Float	**148M sh**
P/E (TTM)	**22.9**
Fwd P/E	**15.2**
Rev Growth	**4.1%**
Short %	**5.7%**
Inst. Own	**-**
Target Pr.	**$30.03**

ENTRY TRIGGER

Close above $31.90 on volume >150% of 20-day average (>6.06M shares)

Target: $36 (measured move toward prior 52-week high of $36.80)

Stop: $28.50 (base low and VCP invalidation)

CATALYST INTELLIGENCE

EARNINGS

November 4

Price within 0.8% of pivot is attractive for timing, but prox_52w at only 86% indicates the stock is well off highs - this is a recovery play, not a leadership setup. RS line NOT at new high, base_tight is loose (4.49), and modest volume contraction (14.7%). Healthcare sector leadership is a tailwind. Reported 9 days ago; no near-term catalyst. Monitor for RS improvement. Conviction: Low.

